

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 768

By Vital

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Eugene M. Pike, Jr., of Chattanooga.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Eugene M. Pike, Jr., of Chattanooga; and

WHEREAS, Eugene Pike was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for his fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Pike graduated from Lafayette High School and furthered his education at the John A. Gupton Mortuary School in Nashville; and

WHEREAS, Gene Pike was hardworking from a young age and took an interest in his father's work as a funeral director at just twelve years old; he began his career at the Chattanooga Funeral Home in 1977 and proudly served as president for forty-eight years; and

WHEREAS, during his distinguished tenure, Mr. Pike conducted the funeral services of a number of Chattanooga citizens and prominent local figures, including Mayors Rudi Olgiati, Robert Kirk Walker, and Gene Roberts; in 1977, he assisted with the funeral service of Elvis Presley at the Ellis Auditorium in Memphis; and

WHEREAS, Chattanooga Funeral Home was acquired by Service Corporation International in 1970, and under Gene Pike's leadership, the funeral home grew to include four chapels, an expanded flower shop, a care center, and a crematory; and

WHEREAS, at one point in his career, Mr. Pike oversaw sixty-five funeral homes throughout the Eastern United States, a testament to his profound ability as a compassionate and diligent professional; and

WHEREAS, Gene Pike was a man of devout faith and devoted his life to Christ at an early age; he was baptized at the age of twelve and joined the First Baptist Church of Lafayette before transferring to Central Baptist Church at Woodmore. He later became a member of Ridgedale Baptist Church, where he served as president of the Friendship Sunday School class, outreach director, and as a deacon, deacon emeritus, and chairman of church finance; and

WHEREAS, a leader in his community, Mr. Pike supported the Vietnam Veterans of America Chapter 203 and assisted with bringing the Vietnam Traveling Memorial Wall to Chattanooga on several occasions; he was proud to have received the Hometown Patriot Award, an honor that recognized his decades of service to area veterans from the Chief John Ross Chapter of the National Society Daughters of the American Revolution; and

WHEREAS, he was also a member of the Chattanooga Civitan Club since 1965, which he served as president; chairman of the Walter Boehm Birth Defect Center; financial chairman of Contact Telephone Ministries; board member of Big Brothers Big Sisters; member of the Freedom Foundation Valley Forge Chattanooga Chapter; president of the Half Century Club of Chattanooga; and chairman of the John A. Gupton Mortuary School, in which capacity he served since 1979; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Pike was deeply devoted to his family, and he always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, left to cherish his memory are his wife of sixty-seven years, Patricia Gail Pedigo Pike; his son, Stephen (Lea) Pike; his granddaughter, Mary (Keshun) Gentry; his great-grandchild, Kingston James Gentry; his brother, Bill (Ellen) Pike; his nephew, Ernie (Linda) Brown; and his niece, Cindy (John) Cagle; and

WHEREAS, he was preceded in death by his parents, Eugene M. Pike, Sr., and Bonnie Pike; and

WHEREAS, for more than six decades, Mr. Pike rendered sterling service to the good people of his community and offered steadfast support to those who had lost family, friends, and loved ones; and

WHEREAS, Gene Pike leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Eugene M. Pike, Jr., reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mr. Pike.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.